Preflight, crew and passengers

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Before you go (91.103; PTS Area III)

- Weather reports and forecasts, PIREPs, SIGMETs and G-AIRMETs; hazards to balloon flight; a go/no-go decision.
- Fuel requirements, and alternatives if the flight can't be completed.
- A course plotted from winds aloft; airspace, obstructions and terrain; landing areas; NOTAMs.
- Operating weight, maximum load, fuel quantity and endurance; envelope temperatures, including never-exceed and maximum continuous.

Launch site (PTS V.A)

Size and surface · access and obstacles · surface wind and winds aloft · obstacles nearby · landing areas downwind · a suitable time for the conditions.

Crew briefing (PTS V.B)

- Designate a crew chief if appropriate, and give each crewmember their duties.
- Brief layout and assembly, tie-off, inflation, in flight, landing, recovery and emergency procedures.
- Agree on a common means of communication: hand signals and/or two-way radio.
- Tell them the expected direction of flight and time aloft. Check that all equipment is on board.

Layout, inspection, inflation (PTS V.C–E)

Fuel system secure, leak-free, correct pressure · cables and lines attached per the flight manual · inspect basket, envelope, suspension and handling lines, vent or deflation system, burner, fuel system, instruments · tie off as the manufacturer specifies · vent/deflation lines positioned and secured.

Passenger briefing (BFH Ch. 6, 8)

Give it before inflation and again once you decide to land:

1. **Stand where shown**: usually the rear of the basket; the front in a high-wind landing.
2. **Face the direction of travel** (or away from it, if that is what you briefed).
3. **Feet and knees together, knees bent.** Avoid the word "brace": legs stay springy.
4. **Hold on tight, in two places.**
5. **Stay in the basket** until the pilot says to get out.

No seat-belt briefing is required in a basket balloon (91.107(a)). Except in an emergency, carry no one who appears intoxicated (91.17(b)).

Pre-launch check (PTS V.F–G)

Loose items secured · wind, temperatures and obstructions reviewed · final instrument check · vent/deflation lines secured · final coordination with crew, including signals and emergency procedures · bring the balloon to equilibrium · no conflict with traffic, above and around.

Sources: 14 CFR 91.17, 14 CFR 91.103, 14 CFR 91.107, FAA-S-8081-18A Areas III and V, FAA-H-8083-11B Ch. 6 (passenger briefing), FAA-H-8083-11B Ch. 8 (passenger briefings and management). Original card, not an FAA document. Study aid, not for navigation.